

THE WEIGHT OF QUIET

Written by

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Working title. One continuous shot, no cuts.
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FADE IN:

EXT. LAKE DISTRICT COTTAGE / FELLS - DUSK

Black. Then the grey ridge of mountains against darker sky.

The camera hangs high above a stone cottage. A single downstairs window burns gold.

It begins to descend. Not a fall. A glide. It snakes down through the cold, tilting toward the light the way a thing comes home.

Closer. The window. The sill. It slips through the gap where the pane sits open.

INT. COTTAGE - LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

And into the warmth.

Two mugs sit abandoned on a side table. One still steaming. One stone cold.

MAYA, 30s, stands by the window. Coat still on. Everything about her is finished except this conversation.

JAMES, 30s, paces. His hands move when he talks. He's been moving for some time.

The camera settles a few feet off his shoulder. He doesn't look at it. But something in him shifts. A small ease. A body that has decided it isn't alone.

MAYA
You're not here.

JAMES
I'm standing right in front of you.

MAYA
You're standing. That's not the same thing.

JAMES
I'm present.

MAYA
Half of you. The other half's somewhere I've never once been allowed.

He turns away from her. Walks to the window. Opens it wider. Cold air rushes in.

MAYA (CONT'D)
Why are you opening that?

JAMES
It's stuffy.

MAYA
It's November. You do it every time. The second a room gets close you open a window, you open a door – you make a way out before you even know you want one.

He closes his eyes for a moment. His head tips, a fraction, toward the space beside him. Just a second. A listening.

The camera drifts slightly closer.

Maya watches him watch something she can't see.

MAYA (CONT'D)
There. Where do you go?

JAMES
Nowhere. I'm right here.

MAYA
Say my name.

JAMES
What?

MAYA
Right now. Without finding me first.

A beat. His head turns – a fraction, toward the space beside him – before it comes back to her.

JAMES
Maya.

MAYA
You had to look for me.

Silence.

MAYA (CONT'D)

You made two cups this morning. I watched you carry both to the table and sit down. And then you saw me in the doorway, and you slid the second one aside. Like you'd been caught at something.

JAMES

I made too much.

MAYA

You measure the coffee. You weigh it out. You have never once made too much of anything.

He moves toward the kitchen. She follows him.

MAYA (CONT'D)

I brought us all the way out here. No signal. No work. Nothing for you to hide behind. I thought if there was nowhere else in the world for you to be, you'd have to be with me.

JAMES

I am with you.

MAYA

You found somewhere anyway. You always find somewhere.

He stops. Reaches for a mug. One of them. It's cold. He sets it down.

JAMES

You're making things up.

MAYA

Then look at me when you say it.

He turns to face her. He does look at her. But his eyes flick — half a second, no more — to the space beside him first.

She sees the flick.

MAYA (CONT'D)

How am I supposed to love someone who's always half-looking over his shoulder for a door I can't even see?

JAMES
You want all of me.

MAYA
I want any of you. I would take the
half you keep back.

JAMES
(beat)
There isn't a half I keep back.
There's just less than you thought
you were getting. I never once told
you there was more.

The words land. She doesn't flinch. That's the frightening part.

He comes toward her. She doesn't move. There's heat between them. Anger. Need.

JAMES (CONT'D)
I do love you.

MAYA
Then be here. Actually be here. Not
your body. You. All of you.

He reaches for her. Pulls her toward him roughly. She bites his shoulder. Raw. Desperate. He holds her. His face turned away. His eyes open.

For a moment they're pressed together. Real. Present.

Then his eyes find the space where the camera hovers. And something breaks in his face.

He pulls away from her.

MAYA (CONT'D)
What?

JAMES
No.

MAYA
James. What is it?

He steps back. Takes another step. His hand comes up, reaching toward the empty air beside him – palm open, at a height, as if to rest on a shoulder that should be there. His fingers an inch from the lens.

And he sees it. Really sees it. Sees what he's doing. Sees the reach. Sees the two mugs and the cold drink and the open window and the whole shape of the evening laid out like evidence.

His face shatters.

JAMES (CONT'D)
(barely)
No.

He steps back from it.

JAMES (CONT'D)
Not tonight. Not now.

The camera follows him. Gentle. It doesn't understand. It comes closer.

JAMES (CONT'D)
(a roar, ragged, at the
empty air)
FUCK OFF!

The camera flinches.

Then it BOLTS. A hard rush back, away from him, across the room, past the cold mug, out through the gap in the window.

EXT. COTTAGE / FELS - CONTINUOUS

Out into the cold and UP. Fast. Climbing hard. The gold window shrinking beneath it.

The mountains. The landscape. The dark.

It stops, high above the roof. Looks down.

Down at the little lit cottage. Down at the one warm window with the man standing in it. Small now. Both hands over his face.

And Maya behind him. Watching him shake at an empty room. Not understanding a second of it.

The camera holds there in the dark. Tilted down. The way you look back at a place you have just been thrown out of.

The way an intruder looks at a house.

FADE OUT.